chapter) and I've had the unique pleasure of spending some quality time with that wild man of Australian cricket, Andrew Symonds.

What a character. Andrew Symonds is not at all like I thought he was. When he was still playing for his country's national team, he came across as this hard-arsed, in-your-face kind of guy. However, having played with him at the Deccan Chargers for the past two years, it turns out he's hilarious – one of the funniest guys I know. He's got a great sense of humour. Problem is, when he's had one too many beers, he's not such an easy guy to be around. He is genuinely scary when he's pissed, but man, when he's sober, he's very funny.

Symonds has a really dry sense of humour, which is complemented by his thick Queensland accent. He loves, for example, to tease Goolam Rajah. Goolam is not only the Proteas' long-time team manager, but the Chargers have also, very wisely, employed this great man's services. Goolam has been doing this job for 17 years and knows everybody in the cricket world. When it comes to a logistical issue, Goolam is your man. I mean, *everyone* respects him, including Symonds, or 'Roy' as we all call him. Apparently it's short for 'Leroy', after Australian basketball star Leroy Loggins. One of Roy's early coaches gave him the nickname because he reckoned he looked like the guy. Amazing what you can find on Wikipedia.

Still, Roy can't resist taking the mickey out of Goolam, especially when it comes to one of his little 'faults'. Goolam is very obliging when the press want an interview or fans want their bats signed. He's like, 'We need to have these bats signed, and then we have a function at 6 p.m.' And then Roy will say, 'Goolam,' in that accent of his, 'Goolam, you always have to say "yes", don't you? You *always* have to say yes. Can't you just say *no* every now and again?' And then he'll look at Goolam with this serious expression. We'll all know that he is taking the piss, but it takes Goolam a moment longer to cotton on.

Ja, once you get to know Roy, he's a very funny guy.

Except, as I said, when he gets drunk. Then he gets a little aggressive. After one of the IPL games this past season, Roy wanted to hit our video analyst. I mean, this guy is part of the squad … one of the boys … and he is small compared to Roy, like … *my* size. We had to talk Roy out of that. Then, later the same evening, Roy took a chair and poked people in the backside. He loves to drink, does Roy. I think he'd drink every day of his life if he could. And fish. Drink and go fishing.